



VICTIMS CART THEIR BELONGINGS ACROSS A MAKESHIFT BRIDGE IN THE FLOOD-HIT DISTRICT OF SUPAUL

FAR FROM PROVIDING RELIEF TO FLOOD VICTIMS, THE STATE GOVERNMENT AND CENTRE ARE BUSY BLAMING EACH OTHER.

embankment on August 18 last year, acrimony and finger-pointing between the state and the Central governments continues unabated.

Worse still, closure of the relief camps during winter has left the flood victims to suffer in extreme cold conditions. Many families are putting up in makeshift bamboo and straw shelters near Gwalpara in Madhepura district. The residents of localities like Bhawara and Singhwari of Madhepura and many others elsewhere are staying at such refuges because the floodwaters washed away their homes. Many who returned to their homes after the water receded have discovered that it has left the land swampy, making the rebuilding process difficult, if not impossible.

Many flood victims squarely blame the state authorities for abruptly closing down the relief camps. According to official records, more than 10 lakh people were rescued and the Government had set up 350 camps across the five flood-affected districts, but these could accommodate no more than 4.5 lakh victims. The Nitish government had also made elaborate promises of providing food and shelter to the flood victims for "as long as required". Instead, the Government seems to have washed its hands off the situation and reportedly ordered closure of the camps after providing cash support of Rs 2,250 per family, besides one quintal of foodgrains.

On face value, however, the Bihar Government has not been entirely callous. Nitish has announced a series of relief initiatives, including Rs 80 crore worth of allocations to buy books for flood-affected students and special grants for newborn babies. But the im-

Killer KOSI

- Although more than 10 lakh people were rescued, the Government had set up only 350 camps across five districts where no more than 4.5 lakh victims could be accommodated
- 2,399 schools out of a total of 7,480 in the five districts were damaged by floodwaters
- Officials claim that the cost of putting back the physical infrastructure in place would be close to Rs 150 crore

washed away their home. But they were left to fend for themselves when the camp was dismantled and they had to leave. In any other state, irrespective of political affiliations, natural calamity always brings everyone, including all government organs, together to ensure complete synergy in dispensing aid. In the beginning, the unprecedented floods caused by the Kosi river in Bihar—described as a "catastrophe" by Chief Minister Nitish Kumar and equated to a "national disaster" by Prime Minister Manmohan Singh—triggered similar textbook responses. Today, almost five months after the Kosi breached its eastern